



△ Polished pebble of peridot

Peridot

The name “peridot” is French, possibly derived from the Arabic word *faridat*, meaning “gem”. This variety of gem-quality olivine has been mined for over 3,500 years – the Red Sea island of Zabargad (now St John’s Island) was the main source of peridot for ancient Mediterranean civilizations. The Greeks and Romans called this island Topazios, and so they named this stone “topaz”, although it has nothing to do with the gem of the same name. Peridot can range from pale golden-green to brownish-green in colour; rich green is the most valued of all.

Specification

Chemical name	Magnesium, iron silicate	Formula	$(\text{Mg,Fe})_2\text{SiO}_4$
Colours	Pale green to brownish-green	Structure	Orthorhombic
Hardness	6.5–7	SG	3.32–3.37
		RI	1.64–1.69
		Lustre	Vitreous to greasy
		Streak	White to greenish
		Locations	China, Myanmar, Norway, USA, Canary Islands, Australia, Sierra Leone

Rough

Crystal | This crystal comes from Sapat, near Naran, Pakistan, the principal source of peridot. It is usually found in dry climates or recently formed rocks.

Pure peridot

Natural fracture

Cut

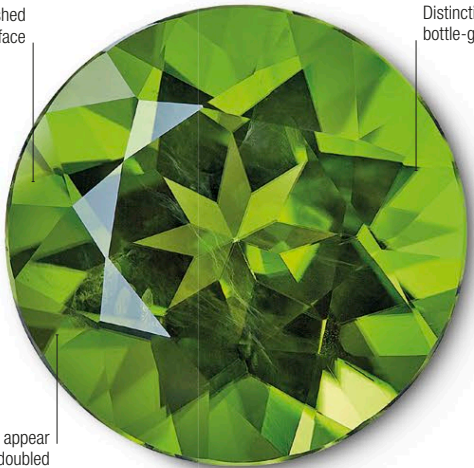


Mixed cut | The cutter of this dark green peridot used a mixture of cuts to maximize brilliance: a scissors-cut crown and a step-cut pavilion.



Multi-sided form

Faceted teardrop | Peridot that is lighter green, as here, tends to be cut with a multitude of facets to deepen its colour and make the most of its transparency.



Polished surface

Distinctive bottle-green colour

Facets appear doubled

Faceted round cut | Because peridot is doubly refractive, the back facets of this stone appear doubled when viewed through the stone, giving great depth of colour.